

Staying safe online

The internet is a useful tool both socially and educationally, but it also has its pitfalls. It's essential that users are aware of the dangers and ways to avoid them.

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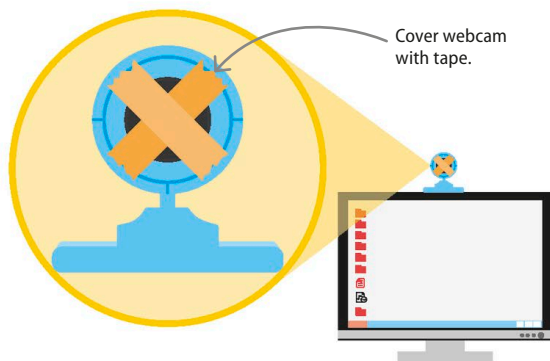
190–191 ▶

Keeping devices safe

The first stage in staying safe online is to keep computers and mobile phones secure. All devices should have up-to-date virus protection. If using a public computer, in a library or at school, remember to log out of accounts before leaving.

▷ Webcam

It's possible for hackers to take control of your webcam and film without permission. Cover the webcam on a computer or phone with stickers, tape, or a cover when not in use.



Dangerous content

The internet gives access to many sites that parents would prefer young people not to see. These can include hate sites, racist sites, websites that encourage anorexia or self-harm, and pornography. Discussing these issues with young people can help counteract this kind of negative influence, as can encouraging them to evaluate what they read critically, comparing it with other sources of information.

REAL WORLD

Sharing personal information

It's important for young people to develop a healthy level of distrust when interacting online, particularly if websites or people ask them for personal information. Contact details, such as email address, phone number, home address, and school, shouldn't be given out to strangers. These can all be used to identify someone's location, which could potentially put them in danger.

◀ Bigoted material

Young people are often anxious to find a group where they belong, but this can make them prey to unpleasant ideologies. Sites that promote racism or sexism, or encourage prejudiced views against minority groups such as gay people, can encourage bad behaviour and, in some cases, criminal acts.



◀ Drugs

The dark web is an underground part of the internet where illegal drugs are readily available. It's also easy to obtain potentially dangerous substances known as "legal highs" online.



◀ Self-harm

Young people who are under stress or struggling with their mental health are particularly at risk from websites that encourage self-harm or suicide. Sites that promote anorexia also exist and can endanger vulnerable teenagers.



◀ Pornography

It's very easy for young people to access sexually explicit content on the internet, as many sites don't require any payment. Activating parental controls on devices and internet connections can help restrict access to these sites at home.

